EL NIÑO ACTION BRIEFING · 26 OCTOBER 2026

Downtown Winnipeg, Manitoba

Cold, not heat, is the danger here. A mild El Niño winter still brings cold snaps, so open warming space on a fixed date, not after a death.

IMPACT REGION	EXCESS HEAT DEATHS	WINDOW	DOMINANT HAZARD
Winnipeg, Manitoba (inferred)	None published for Canada	n/a here; global 6-month figure 239,000 ± 11,000	Cold snaps inside a mild winter: hypothermia with intoxication, fires in vacant buildings, and drug poisoning

13/13 recommendations checked. 0 confirmed outright, 8 corrected, 0 unverified, 5 contraindicated (the five Do-not cards; one anecdote behind the second could not be traced and was dropped). The five resident steps were checked separately: 2 confirmed, 3 corrected. Funding target C$790,000 (US$564,600), down 3% from C$815,000 (US$582,400) in verification. Exposure figure: Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk*, September 2026, pre-peer-review, heat only. It publishes no figure for Canada, and heat is not this place's winter hazard, so the historical record carries the risk here.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE



49.90°N 97.14°W, Canada · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** El Niño winters here run warm, but not safe. January 2024, in a strong El Niño, still brought wind chills near −40, and people outside carry the risk.
- **For you.** By 30 November, fit a CO alarm (about C$40, US$29) on every level. Landlords here don't have to supply one.
- **The money.** C$250,000 floor, C$790,000 target, about C$1.5 million ceiling (US$178,700 / US$564,600 / US$1.07 million). First: open Siloam's warming space by 15 November.
- **Do not.** Do not open warming space only at a wind-chill threshold or after a death. In a Toronto study, 72% of hypothermia cases came on nights warmer than −15 °C.

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* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHERE THIS BRIEFING APPLIES — SCOPE

The request named Winnipeg, a whole city. This briefing covers Downtown, where the cold risk is sharpest; other neighbourhoods can be prepared on request. Statistics describe the City of Winnipeg's Downtown Community Area (2021 census), which is wider than the core. It has 68,445 people. 44.7% live alone (city 30.2%), 66.0% rent (city 36.9%), and 17.8% are Indigenous (city 12.4%). 1,765 people (2.6%) speak neither English nor French. The 2024 Street Census counted 2,469 unhoused people citywide, about 80% Indigenous and 67.9% chronically homeless; its figures are disputed, and there is no Downtown breakdown.

El Niño here: strong El Niño winters are reliably among the warmest (1982-83, 1997-98, 2015-16, and 2023-24). 2023-24 was the second-warmest on record, with a record-low number of days below −20 °C. Cold still kills inside them.

FOR YOU, AS A RESIDENT — 5 STEPS

For a Downtown resident, an El Niño winter means fewer deep-cold days, not none. The dangers are a cold snap that catches someone outside, a space heater too close to the bed, and carbon monoxide in an old building. The ranked actions below are written for the City and its partners. These are the ones you can take yourself.

1 · On a bitterly cold night, call 911 for anyone in a transit shelter or doorway who does not respond*

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED — FROM ACTIONS 1 AND 3

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
All winter	None	People sleeping outside

In December 2016 a woman of 53 was found dead on the 300 block of Portage Avenue at a −32 wind chill, about two hours after firefighters were called to people frozen there. Save the City's Winter Weather Response Plan when it is published; it lists shelters and outreach. We could not verify this winter's outreach or information-line numbers, so check any number before you rely on it.

2 · Put a carbon monoxide alarm on every level and outside each sleeping area by 30 November

CONFIRMED — FROM ACTION 5

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

30 Nov 2026	About C$40 (US$29) per alarm (estimate)	Everyone asleep in the home

This is Winnipeg Fire Paramedic Service advice: if the alarm sounds, leave the building and call 911. Landlords in Manitoba do not have to supply one, except in new builds and seniors' and care housing. Two in three Downtown households rent, so most residents need to buy their own.*

3 · Know the heat rule, and keep anything that can burn at least one metre from a space heater*

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED FROM ACTION 5

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
All winter	None	Your household and your building

The City's by-law requires 21 °C from 7 am to 11 pm and 18 °C from 11 pm to 7 am. If your home is colder, tell your landlord or caretaker first, then the Residential Tenancies Branch or 311. Turn a space heater off when you leave the room or go to bed. On 14 November 2023 a space heater near combustibles started a fire in a Maryland Street house; one firefighter was injured.

4 · If your Hydro account is 60 or more days overdue, book a Neighbours Helping Neighbours appointment before December

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED FROM ACTION 6

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
30 Nov 2026	None; up to C$500 (US$360) toward what you owe	Heat and power at home

This applies only if the Manitoba Hydro account is in your name; many Downtown renters have heat in their rent. Call the Salvation Army (204-949-2106) for an in-person meeting, and bring proof of income for everyone in the home. It pays up to C$500 (US$360) for an electric-heated home and C$400 (US$290) otherwise, never more than you owe, once every two years. The after-tax income limit for one person is C$32,386 (US$23,100). If you don't qualify, call Hydro (1-888-624-9376) about an arrears plan; that is a repayment plan, not a grant.

5 · File your 2025 tax return at a free volunteer clinic to receive the Canada Groceries and Essentials Benefit

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

CONFIRMED FROM ACTION 6

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
As soon as you can	None at a volunteer clinic	Up to C$679 (US$485) a year for a single person

Find a clinic with the CRA's free tax clinic finder. The next payment is expected in early January 2027. If you file late, the CRA must assess your return before it pays.

What to ask of the people in charge

- Ask the City to publish the Winter Weather Response Plan in November, not January (action 1).
- Ask your councillor for a cold-warning exception to daytime encampment enforcement (action 4).
- Donate toques, mitts, and socks to Main Street Project.

WHAT THIS PLACE SHOULD DO — RANKED

Ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak. Backing lenses are shown per action; an action several lenses reached independently is the stronger bet. Every action was corrected in verification; the text below is the corrected version.

1. Open on a date, not after a death: Siloam Mission's overnight warming space open by 15 November, and overflow that opens on every extreme cold warning

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED EMERGENCY MANAGER · PUBLIC HEALTH · SKEPTIC · ECONOMIST · HISTORIAN · PHILANTHROPIST

ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
City of Winnipeg, with Siloam Mission and End Homelessness Winnipeg (EHW)	Siloam open by 15 Nov 2026; plan published in November	C$250,000 (US$178,700) bridge, only if needed; C$265,000 (US$189,400) overflow fund	Hypothermia and frostbite on cold-snap nights

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Siloam's Winter Overnight Warming Space at 300 Princess St has 116 spaces. It opens 8:30 pm to 7 am, with no temperature threshold. In 2024 it opened on 18 December, on Winnipeg Foundation money while other funding was confirmed. In 2025 it opened on 8 November, funded by the Province and the Winnipeg Foundation, and served more than 4,000 people. We found no 2026-27 announcement as of 26 October. If the Province has not confirmed by about 1 November, a C$250,000 (US$178,700) bridge, co-funded with the Winnipeg Foundation, opens it by 15 November.

The Homelessness Emergency Response Committee and EHW's Extreme Weather Response Committee should publish the Winter Weather Response Plan in November. The 2023-24 plan came out on 9 January 2024, and the 2025-26 plan on 15 January 2026. They should also pre-agree that overflow at other sites opens on any Environment and Climate Change Canada (ECCC) extreme cold warning, with the staff to open it. The 2023-24 pop-up (Siloam, 1JustCity, Main Street Project, and Sunshine House) cost C$265,000 (US$189,400): C$200,000 (US$142,900) from the City and C$65,000 (US$46,500) from EHW's Reaching Home. It opened only on a "feels like" −10 °C forecast three days ahead, with all shelters full and at least four staff.

Evidence: a Toronto case-crossover study of homeless adults, 2004–15 (Zhang et al. 2019), found 97 hypothermia events, 18 of them deaths. Each 5 °C drop in minimum temperature raised the odds by 64% (OR 1.64), and 72% of cases came on nights warmer than −15 °C. Toronto staff proposed moving its trigger from −15 °C to −5 °C plus storm warnings in April 2023.

Transferability: Toronto is milder than Winnipeg, so the finding transfers in direction, not in size. No study tests opening dates directly.

2. Make every warming space low-barrier, with naloxone, and extend hours at the 366 Henry Ave supervised consumption site through the coldest weeks

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · SKEPTIC · EMERGENCY MANAGER · FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Province of Manitoba and Shared Health, with the Aboriginal Health and Wellness Centre	**1 Dec 2026**	**Not costed**	**Drug-poisoning deaths, and people turned away into the cold**

Every warming space stocks naloxone and admits people who are intoxicated. Main Street Project is the local model; its current admission policy was not verified. The supervised consumption site at 366 Henry Ave, run by the Aboriginal Health and Wellness Centre, has been fully open since 11 August 2026. Its hours are Tuesday to Saturday, 11 am to 6:45 pm, as announced. Extend them through the coldest

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

weeks.

Evidence: in Vancouver, overdose deaths within 500 m of a supervised site fell 35% (253.8 to 165.1 per 100,000 person-years), against 9.3% in the rest of the city (Marshall et al., Lancet 2011). Manitoba recorded 570 substance-related deaths in 2024 and 388 in 2025, down 31.9%.

Transferability: the Vancouver study is a pre/post comparison from 2001–05, before fentanyl, and says nothing about cold. The Manitoba figures are provincial; no Downtown count exists.

3. Check on people on foot on cold-warning nights: a second overnight crew for Main Street Project's outreach, with Bear Clan Patrol walkers

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · FRONTLINE · HISTORIAN · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Main Street Project, with the City of Winnipeg consulted	1 Dec 2026	About C$225,000 (US$160,800) for about 150 nights (estimate)	Deaths in transit shelters, tents, and doorways

Main Street Project holds the City's 24/7 outreach contract, re-awarded on 20 March 2026. The earlier contract paid C$275,000 (US$196,500) for July to December 2025, and up to C$550,000 (US$393,100) a year. A second crew for about 150 nights costs about C$225,000 (US$160,800): C$550,000 × 150 ÷ 365. That is our arithmetic on the contract ceiling, not a quote. The crew checks transit shelters and tents, carries naloxone, and gives rides. Bear Clan Patrol walkers join. Their current capacity is unverified, and the founder settled a defamation suit in April 2026, so check references first.

Precedent: on 11 December 2016 a woman of 53 died on the 300 block of Portage Avenue at a −32 wind chill. Firefighters had been called there about two hours earlier to "multiple frozen people". The fire union president believed she had walked away at the sirens. That is his belief, not an autopsy finding.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: no study measures the effect of outreach checks; this rests on local case records. The City contract requires compliance with the encampment policy, which pulls against action 4. A second crew paid for by a funder would not carry that clause.

4. Stop pushing people into vacant buildings in the cold: a cold-warning exception to daytime encampment enforcement, and repeat-fire vacant buildings inspected and boarded before December

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | SKEPTIC · EMERGENCY MANAGER · PUBLIC HEALTH · HISTORIAN | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
City Council, with Winnipeg Fire Paramedic Service (WFPS) and by-law enforcement	Council decision and inspections by 1 Dec 2026	A council decision; board-ups not costed	Fires in vacant buildings set for warmth

Council's encampment policy CO-024 was approved in September 2025 and enforced from 17 November 2025. It bans camping in daytime: camping is allowed only from one hour before sunset to one hour after sunrise. It also sets a 30 m priority zone around transit shelters. It has no cold-weather exception. The City says it has not torn down an active camp to date. Ask council for an exception while ECCC cold warnings are in force. Before December, inspect and board Downtown vacant buildings with repeat fire records under the vacant buildings by-law.

The record: vacant-building fires reached a record 156 in 2023 and 274 in 2024 (CTV; not re-checked). In May 2026 crews answered 9 fires in 24 hours, 6 of them at vacant properties.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: no evaluation shows that board-ups cut fires. The policy's own definition of unsheltered includes people in abandoned buildings, which is the displacement this action is meant to stop.

5. Carbon monoxide alarms, naloxone, and heat checks in Downtown rooming houses, seniors' blocks, and camps

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · SKEPTIC · FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
WFPS, with tenant associations	30 Nov 2026	About C$20,000 (US$14,300): 500 alarms × about C$40 (US$29) (estimate)	Carbon monoxide poisoning and heater fires

WFPS created an encampment liaison role in 2023, which already hands out CO detectors and naloxone. Scale it to Downtown rooming houses and seniors' blocks; whether the role is still filled in 2026 was not verified. Manitoba does not require landlords to install CO alarms. Only new builds and seniors' and care housing must have them.

Tenant volunteers in seniors' blocks and rooming houses check on neighbours on extreme-cold days, and on the heat rule. Neighbourhood Liveability By-law 1/2008 sets 21 °C from 7 am to 11 pm and 18 °C from 11 pm to 7 am. Tenants tell the landlord first, then the Residential Tenancies Branch or 311.

Transferability: no outcome study measures alarm hand-outs here, and the alarm price is an estimate. The practice already exists in Winnipeg; this scales it.

6. Money that keeps the heat on: Hydro arrears grants, a published winter disconnection rule, and tax filing for the Canada Groceries and Essentials Benefit

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST · FOOD SUPPLY | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Manitoba Hydro, with the Salvation Army and CRA volunteer clinics	1 Dec 2026	None to a funder; grants are donor-funded	Lost heat and income in winter (income protection)

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Neighbours Helping Neighbours runs through the Salvation Army Winnipeg (204-949-2106). It pays up to C$500 (US$360) for an electric-heated home and C$400 (US$290) otherwise, capped at the overdue amount. It needs 60 or more days in arrears, no grant in the last two years, and after-tax income of C$32,386 (US$23,100) or less for one person. Applicants meet the Salvation Army in person with proof of income. Hydro's Customer Arrears Assistance Plan is a repayment plan, not a grant.

The current winter disconnection rule is unverified. A 2008 Public Utilities Board order used load limiters in the heating season, not disconnection. Ask the Public Utilities Board to publish the current rule. Tax filing lets residents receive the Canada Groceries and Essentials Benefit: up to C$679 (US$485) for a single person, July 2026 to June 2027, with the next payment expected in early January 2027. Point people to the CRA's free clinic finder.

Transferability: this is income protection. No study links arrears grants to fewer cold deaths.

7. Food on the coldest nights: a substitution plan ready if fresh-vegetable prices jump, and extra cold-night meals as a candidate

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FOOD SUPPLY | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Harvest Manitoba	30 Nov 2026	Plan: none. Meals: C$225,000 (US$160,800), a candidate outside the target	Hunger if prices spike

The El Niño food signal here is weak. Statistics Canada reported on 19 October 2026: food from stores +1.7% year on year, fresh vegetables −2.9%, beef +8.7%, and all items +3.1%. Harvest Manitoba and meal programmes prepare a substitution plan, using frozen food and Manitoba storage crops. The trigger is fresh-vegetable CPI above +10% year on year (Table 18-10-0004-01, monthly, about three weeks' lag). The 2016 El Niño cauliflower spike was mostly a currency shock.

Extra cold-night meals at Siloam and Main Street Project are a candidate: 500 meals × C$5 (US$3.60) × 90 nights = C$225,000 (US$160,800). The unit cost is unsourced, and provincial warming-space money may already cover these meals.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: the CPI is national. No Manitoba food figure appears in the release.

8. A cold card people can read, in the languages Downtown speaks, handed out by outreach walkers and at the Millennium Library

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
End Homelessness Winnipeg	30 Nov 2026	About C$200 (US$140) for printing (estimate)	People not knowing where warm space is

Print it in English, Tagalog, Tigrinya, Somali, Amharic, Arabic, and Ojibway, and in Portuguese, Vietnamese, and Spanish if space allows. It lists the warming space, the shelters, and the outreach van. Confirm every number before printing. Outreach walkers hand it out, and so does the Millennium Library's Downtown Resource Corner, which is open mostly in the afternoons; the library is closed on Sundays.

In the Downtown Community Area, 1,765 people (2.6%) speak neither English nor French. Languages people can speak include Tagalog (7,150), Tigrinya (1,475; Tigrigna in the census), Portuguese (1,285), Arabic (965), Vietnamese (835), Spanish (825), Somali (765), Amharic (750), and Ojibway (235).

Transferability: the census counts languages people can speak, not the language they use at home. No study measures the effect of a cold card.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHO DOES WHAT

RACI CHART

R = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

Action	City of Winnipeg	Province / Shared Health	EHW	Siloam Mission	Main Street Project	WFPS	AHWC	Manitoba Hydro	Salvation Army	Harvest Manitoba	Community groups
1. Open on a date; overflow on every warning	**A**	**C**	**R**	**R**	**C**	**I**					**I**
2. Low-barrier spaces, naloxone, longer site hours	**I**	**A**	**C**	**R**	**R**		**R**				
3. Overnight checks on foot	**C**		**C**		**A/R**	**I**					**R**
4. Cold-warning exception; vacant buildings	**A/R**		**C**		**C**	**R**					
5. CO alarms, naloxone, heat checks	**C**				**I**	**A/R**					**R**
6. Money that keeps the heat on		**C**						**A**	**R**		**R**
7. Food on the coldest nights		**I**		**C**	**C**					**A/R**	
8. Cold card	**R**		**A/R**		**R**						**R**

Community groups are Bear Clan Patrol (actions 3 and 8), tenant associations (action 5), and CRA volunteer tax clinics (action 6). The City's column includes council, by-law enforcement, and the Millennium Library. AHWC is the Aboriginal Health and Wellness Centre; EHW is End Homelessness Winnipeg; WFPS is Winnipeg Fire Paramedic Service. What the chart shows: the City carries the most rows and is accountable for the two that matter most, the opening date and the encampment exception. Action 4 needs a council decision rather than money, and action 6 needs the Public Utilities Board to publish a rule.

WHERE MONEY DOES THE MOST

FUNDING

The Philanthropist lens, reconciled against the ranked actions and verified. Placements are ranked by marginal lives saved per dollar. The envelope is bounded by what this place can spend before the peak, not by what it needs. No placement carries a measured cost per death averted.

FLOOR	TARGET	CEILING	LARGEST UNCERTAINTY
C$250,000 (US$178,700)	**C$790,000 (US$564,600)**	**About C$1.5 million (US$1.07 million)**	**Whether the Province renews Siloam's funding in time**

Floor: the Siloam bridge, C$250,000 (US$178,700). **Target:** C$250,000 + C$265,000 + C$225,000 + C$50,000 = C$790,000 (US$564,600). It fell 3% in verification, from C$815,000 (US$582,400), because the outreach crew was re-costed from the City contract ceiling. **Ceiling:** about C$1.5 million (US$1.07 million). In 2021 the Province gave EHW C$1.5 million (US$1.07 million) for N'Dinawemak, up to 150 overnight beds,

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

and it opened within weeks. That shows how fast the system can absorb money; it is in 2021 dollars and is not a cost standard. Beyond it, the limit is trained night staff.

If the Province confirms Siloam before about 1 November, the bridge drops out. The floor becomes C$265,000 (US$189,400) and the target C$540,000 (US$385,900). **Outside the target:** cold-night meals, C$225,000 (US$160,800), until operators confirm the gap; and CO alarms, C$20,000 (US$14,300), through WFPS. **Already funded, so do not duplicate:** the federal–provincial encampments agreement, C$7.5 million (US$5.4 million) from each government over two years from February 2025, with winter services at nine drop-ins (which of them are Downtown is unverified); the Downtown Community Safety Partnership; and the City's outreach contract.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
Siloam Mission, co-funded with the Winnipeg Foundation	Action 1: open the warming space by 15 November	C$250,000 (US$178,700)	Bridge grant, released only if the Province has not confirmed by about 1 November	The same space opened about 40 nights earlier in 2025 than in 2024, once money was confirmed. The Winnipeg Foundation has bridged it twice.	Partially confirmed
End Homelessness Winnipeg, pooled	Action 1: overflow and staffing at sites other than Siloam	C$265,000 (US$189,400)	Pooled fund, released on an ECCC extreme cold warning	Sized on the 2023-24 one-off pop-up. That pop-up was at Siloam, now replaced by the warming space, so this must not fund the same beds. A new instrument, not a renewal.	Partially confirmed
Main Street Project	Action 3: a second overnight outreach crew	C$225,000 (US$160,800)	Direct grant, additional to the City contract	C$550,000 (US$393,100) contract ceiling × 150 ÷ 365; our arithmetic	Partially confirmed
Bear Clan Patrol	Action 3: winter gear for foot patrols	C$50,000 (US$35,700)	Pre-positioned stock, after a reference check, or routed through Main Street Project	Capacity figures date from 2018; no current figure found	Unverified

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The funder's one thing: the cheapest life saved comes from fixing the opening date, not adding beds. The same space opened about 40 nights earlier in 2025 than in 2024, and the only difference was when the money was confirmed.

Do not do this

CONTRAINDICATED · ADVICE THAT WOULD COST LIVES HERE

Advice that circulates for this hazard and would cost lives here.

Do not open warming space only at a wind-chill threshold, or only after someone dies

CONTRAINDICATED

In December 2023 a warming site opened only after a death in a bus shelter (CBC, via a secondary summary). The 2023-24 pop-up needed a −10 °C forecast, full shelters, and four staff before it opened. In Toronto, 72% of hypothermia cases among homeless adults came on nights warmer than −15 °C.

Instead: open on a fixed date, and open overflow on every ECCC extreme cold warning (action 1).

Do not count beds as protection when they turn away people who are intoxicated

CONTRAINDICATED

People who are turned away end up in bus shelters. Main Street Project is the main shelter that admits them. In Toronto, intoxication was common among people with hypothermia.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Instead: make every warming space low-barrier, with naloxone on hand (action 2).

Do not enforce the daytime encampment ban and transit-shelter priority zones through cold warnings

CONTRAINDICATED

It pushes people into vacant buildings, and that is where the fires are: a record 156 vacant-building fires in 2023 and 274 in 2024 (not re-checked).

Instead: a cold-warning exception, and repeat-fire buildings boarded before December (action 4).

Do not just tell people in tents not to heat them *

CONTRAINDICATED

They will heat them anyway, with candles, propane, or fires. That is the City's own warning, and it carries a high carbon monoxide risk.

Instead: pair the warning with a CO alarm, naloxone, and a ride to a warm space (actions 3 and 5).

Do not stand down because the El Niño forecast is mild

CONTRAINDICATED

January 2024, in a strong El Niño, brought extreme cold warnings with wind chills near −40. In December 2023, the warm El Niño December, two people were found dead in a tent in Joe Zuken Park; the cause was not released. Winter 2018-19, a weak El Niño, was Winnipeg's coldest in about 40 years.

Instead: run the full cold plan every winter, whatever the seasonal forecast.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
Dec 1877, 1997, 2023	Winnipeg's three warmest Decembers, all strong El Niño years (1877 by proxy)	None recorded	Nothing
1982-83, 1997-98, 2015-16	Winters among the warmest on record, all strong El Niño (ranking from a secondary summary)	None recorded	Nothing
2010–17	Hypothermia deaths in Winnipeg (Chief Medical Examiner, via CBC; not fetched directly)	24 deaths	Not known
11 Dec 2016	Woman, 53, died outside on the 300 block of Portage Ave at a −32 wind chill	1 death	Shelters reported turning people away the same day
Winter 2018-19	Weak El Niño, yet the coldest winter in about 40 years; February 2019 tied 23rd-coldest February	Not known	Nothing
2021-22	Frostbite in Winnipeg, a 10-year high (Shared Health, citywide)	90 cases, 19 amputations	Not known
Dec 2022	Woman found dead in a transit shelter at Taché Ave and Goulet St (St. Boniface, outside Downtown), on a record-cold night; about 750 emergency beds near capacity (not re-checked)	1 death	Not known
2023, 2024	Vacant-building fires (CTV; not re-checked)	156 fires (record), then 274	Not known
11 Dec 2023	Two people found dead in a tent in Joe Zuken Park (Point Douglas, just outside Downtown), in a strong El Niño December; cause not released	2 deaths	Not known

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
Jan 2024	Extreme cold warnings in a strong El Niño, wind chill near −40; the Siloam pop-up held about 100 people a night	Not known	Winter plan published only on 9 January
Sept–Nov 2025	Encampment policy CO-024 approved, then enforced from 17 November	—	Daytime camping ban, with no cold-weather exception
May 2026	9 fires in 24 hours, 6 at vacant properties	Not known	Not known

The Historian's one thing: in Winnipeg, El Niño winters are when the city relaxes and the dying continues.

WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE — RESOLVED

- **The Historian: great Red River floods follow La Niña or neutral winters (1950, 1997, 2009, 2011), so El Niño lowers the 2027 risk** versus **the Skeptic: no study makes that link.** Resolved toward the Skeptic. No study links El Niño to lower Red River flood risk. Fall soil moisture and spring storms decide it. The flood list is selective: the 2019 flood followed a weak El Niño (from memory, not fetched). Manitoba's March 2026 outlook gave low to moderate runoff potential, except in parts of southern Manitoba and the US Red and Souris basins, where soil moisture at freeze-up was near to above normal. Manitoba's fall conditions report, expected in December, is the first real signal. Keep the April flood watch either way.

WHAT NOBODY COVERED — BLIND SPOT

No Downtown-level death data exists for cold, fire, or drug poisoning; every figure is citywide or provincial. Nobody counts people sheltering inside vacant buildings. That is the group actions 3 and 4 are aimed at, and its size could change how much outreach and enforcement relief is worth.

HOW TO READ THIS — METHOD

The panel is author-built. Eight simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and

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feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale, roughly 300,000 people. They are not neighbourhood figures. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*, and publishes nothing for Canada. Cold, fire, and drug poisoning are carried here by the historical record rather than by a published number.

HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED

METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The requester typed "Winnipeg"; this briefing covers Downtown Winnipeg, Manitoba, using the City of Winnipeg's Downtown Community Area for statistics. Climate Impact Lab impact region, as the report records it: Winnipeg, Manitoba (inferred). Mortality figures exist only at that scale (impact regions average roughly 300,000 people); sub-city detail is used for hazard exposure and action design, not for death counts.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February 2027. It covers heat only. It is never added to the Impact Map's long-run projections or quoted from the map's GDP-denominated mortality. Heat is not the dominant hazard here, so the historical record carries the hazard instead of a borrowed number.
- **Expert panel.** Eight simulated expert lenses (emergency manager, public health scientist, frontline responder, skeptic, economist, historian, philanthropist, and food supply chain analyst) each researched this place independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief that named the resident reader.
- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias (whether the evidence behind an agreed action came from a setting like this one) before it counted in an action's favour. Contradictions were kept, not resolved by dropping a side. Actions were ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak, each was given a named payer and trigger or marked unfunded, and the funding placements were reconciled against the ranked list.
- **Verification.** Separate verifier agents checked every recommendation on three tests: evidence (the primary source and its effect size), transferability (whether that evidence came from somewhere like here), and feasibility (whether it can be done here before the peak). Financial actions were also checked for availability in this jurisdiction, a named payer, a trigger threshold, and whether they already exist. The funding envelope was checked for real recipients, published unit costs, and duplication, then re-summed.
- **Who does what.** The RACI chart is built from the owners named in the verified actions, with one accountable party per action. It is a proposal: no organisation named in it has been contacted or has agreed to a role.

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- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.
- **Adaptation Inventory.** Not consulted for this run.
- **Money.** Costs are shown in Canadian dollars with US dollars in parentheses, at C$1.3993 = US$1 (Bank of Canada daily exchange rate, 23 October 2026). Converted figures are rounded.
- **Reader.** No role was given, so the For you section is written for a resident. The steps were taken from the verified actions and checked separately on the same three tests (2 confirmed, 3 corrected). The rest of the report is written for the City and its partners.
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (cold-weather danger and when to call 911, carbon monoxide alarms, space heaters and fire, and heating tents) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.
- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total without saying so, and no local figure is invented; where data is thin, the report says so and shows the containing geography's number with its arithmetic. Every source is listed below with its verification status.
- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts, and no one in this place was interviewed. CBC pages were blocked, so several facts come from secondary summaries. The City's census PDF was extracted locally. Siloam's 2026-27 funding and the 2026-27 Winter Weather Response Plan were unknown at writing. Manitoba's fall flood conditions report is not yet out.

References · status in brackets
Siloam Mission, Winter Overnight Warming Space [confirmed] · A warm welcome, 2025-26 [confirmed]
City of Winnipeg, pop-up shelter funding, 15 Nov 2023 [confirmed] · Winter Weather Response Plan, 9 Jan 2024 [confirmed] · Southern Chiefs' Organization, 2025-26 plan, 15 Jan 2026 [confirmed] · Main Street Project, Extreme Weather Response Committee [confirmed]
Zhang P et al. 2019, Int J Environ Res Public Health 16:3259 [confirmed] · Global News, Toronto warming-centre criteria, Apr 2023 [confirmed; a proposal]
Marshall BDL et al., Lancet 2011;377:1429–37, summary [confirmed] · CTV, 366 Henry Ave full opening [confirmed; hours as announced] · Manitoba, substance-related deaths [confirmed]
City of Winnipeg, 24/7 mobile outreach contract, 20 Mar 2026 [confirmed] · CBC 1.7576877, prior contract value [confirmed via search] · CBC, Portage Ave death, 11 Dec 2016 [confirmed via search snippets; page blocked] · Global News 11799967, Bear Clan settlement [partially checked]
City of Winnipeg, encampments policy page [confirmed] · enforcement from 17 Nov 2025 [confirmed] · CBC, council approval [confirmed via search] ·

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CTV, vacant-house fires 2023-24 [not re-checked] · CP24, May 2026 fires [reported, not fetched]
Global News, WFPS encampment liaison [confirmed for 2023] · Manitoba RTB, CO alarms in rentals [confirmed] · City of Winnipeg, property standards and heat [confirmed] · CBC, heat by-law times [confirmed via search] · City of Winnipeg, Maryland St fire, 14 Nov 2023 [confirmed] · Global News, heating inside tents [confirmed]
Manitoba Hydro, Neighbours Helping Neighbours [confirmed] · payment help [confirmed] · Public Utilities Board, Order 102/08 [unverified as current] · CRA, CGEB amounts and payment dates [confirmed]
Statistics Canada, CPI, September 2026 [confirmed] · Vegetable Growers News, 2016 cauliflower prices [lens source, not re-checked]
City of Winnipeg, Downtown Community Area, 2021 census [confirmed, extracted locally] · CTV, Downtown Resource Corner [confirmed] · CTV, 2024 Street Census [lens source; figures disputed]
Manitoba, N'Dinawemak funding, Nov 2021 [confirmed] · Government of Canada, encampments agreement, Feb 2025 [not re-fetched]
Global News, warmest Decembers [lens source] · University of Manitoba, winter 2023-24 [lens source] · A Weather Moment, winter rankings [secondary, not re-checked] · Global News, February 2019 [lens source] · CBC, January 2024 cold and Siloam pop-up [not re-checked] · CBC, Joe Zuken Park, Dec 2023 [confirmed; cause not released] · CBC, hypothermia deaths 2010–17 [unverified directly] · CBC, frostbite 2021-22 [confirmed] · CBC, transit shelter death, Dec 2022 [not re-checked] · NOAA CPC, ONI
Manitoba, March 2026 flood outlook [confirmed] · 2025 fall conditions report [confirmed; 2026 edition not yet out] · flood history [lens source]
Bank of Canada, FXUSDCAD, 23 Oct 2026 [confirmed]
Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory
Generated 26 October 2026 for Downtown Winnipeg, Manitoba. El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

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